(What is wrong, he is a prince). Other BJP leaders admitted to me privately that Modi's language could at times be coarse, but as one of them reminded me, 'Elections aren't a place for politeness!'

Sniffing victory, Modi became even more belligerent. He would fine-tune his speech to suit the location. In Bihar and UP, the thrust remained on governance and the Gujarat model, but in Assam and Bengal, he did raise the more communally charged issue of Bangladeshi migrants. 'You don't expect him to talk of bullet trains in Assam,' said one BJP leader to me sarcastically. It was classic *rajneeti* (politics).

Earlier, he had been careful about attacking regional leaders. Now in this final phase of campaigning, it was 'Modi versus all'. In Bengal, he attacked Mamata Banerjee for her alleged role in the chit fund scam and even questioned the sale of her paintings. In Odisha, Naveen Patnaik was upbraided for underdevelopment; in Maharashtra, it was the Pawars who were targeted. Even his old friend Jayalalithaa was not spared. 'These are my political adversaries, not my enemies,' he would say later.

The Modi offensive rattled his opponents. Mamata said she would have put the BJP leader in jail if she was in power in Delhi. Her spokesperson Derek O'Brien went a step further by tweeting, 'The butcher of Gujarat who could not take care of his own wife, how will he take care of the nation.' This was, by all accounts, a low blow. Appearing on my programme that night, Derek, a TV quiz host-turned-politician, was unrepentant. 'Read my lips, Rajdeep, Modi is the butcher of Gujarat!' he said with a showman-like elan. As those words echoed on TV I felt quite sure that while the Trinamool seemed to be pandering to its Muslim vote in Bengal, a few more fence-sitter votes might just have been lost nationally.

The story of Modi's wife, Jasodhaben, which Derek raked up, is worth reflecting upon. That Modi had a child marriage and a wife tucked away in the village was one of the worst kept secrets of Gujarat politics. I had tried to meet Jasodhaben once during the 2007 Gujarat assembly elections, only to be advised by a local friend to avoid bringing up the issue. 'Modi is very sensitive about it. Best not to interview her and only worsen relations with